

HP's latest mantra is the 'new style of IT'. Conventional servers and data storage systems do not work for the company and its style of IT any longer. This is about the evolution of converged systems that have taken over the traditional forms of IT. The company is taking its mantra forward in every possible way.

HP has recently launched the HP Apollo family of high-performance computing (HPC) systems. The company claims that HP Apollo is capable of delivering up to four times the performance of standard rack servers while using less space and energy. The new offerings reset data centre expectations by combining a modular design with improvised power distribution and cooling techniques. Apart from this, the company claims that HP Apollo has a higher density at a lower total cost of ownership. The air-cooled HP Apollo 6000 System maximises performance efficiency and makes HPC capabilities accessible to a wide range of enterprise customers. It is a supercomputer that combines high levels of processing power with a water-cooling design for ultra-low energy usage.

These servers add to the fast pace of changes going on in the IT space today. Vikram K from HP shares his deep insight into how IT is changing. Read on...

Q Since you have just launched your latest servers here, what is your take on the Indian server market?

From a server standpoint, we are very excited, because virtually every month and a half, we've been offering a new enhancement or releasing a new product, which is different from the previous one. So the question is - how are these different? Well, we have basically gone back and looked at things through the eyes of the customer to understand what they expect from IT. They want to get away from conventional IT and move to an improvised level of IT. So we see three broad areas: admin controlled IT; user controlled IT, which is more like the cloud and is workload specific; and then there is application-specific 'compute and serve' IT. These are the three distinct combinations. Within these three areas, we have had product launches, one after the other. The first one, of course, is an area where we dominate. So, we decided to extend the lead and that is how the innovations continue to happen.

Q What do you mean by 'new style of IT'?

It is the time for converged systems, which are opening up an altogether new dimension of IT. With converged systems, you get three different systems comprising the compute part, and the storage and the networking parts, to work together. A variety of IT heads are opting for this primarily because they want to either centralise IT, consolidate or improve the overall efficiency and performance. When they do that, they need to have better converged systems management. So we have combined our view of converged systems and made them workload specific. These days we have workload specific systems. For example, with something like a column-

oriented database like Vertica, we have a converged system for virtualisation. Some time back, servers were a sprawl, but these days, virtual machines are a big sprawl.

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Q Converged systems have been around for about 18 months now. Can you throw some light on customers' experiences with these systems?

Yes, converged systems have been around for a while now and we have incrementally improved on their management. What we have today as a CSM for virtualisation or CSM for Hanna, wasn't there a year back. The journey has been good and plenty of enterprises have expressed interest in such evolved IT. With respect to the adoption rate, the IT/ATES segment has been the first large adopter of converged systems, primarily because it has a huge issue about just doing the systems integration of 'X' computers that compute 'Y' storage while somebody else takes care of the networks. Now, it is the time for systems that come integrated with all three elements, and the best part is that it is very workload specific.

We see a lot of converged systems being adopted in the area of manufacturing also. People who had deployed SAP earlier have some issues. One of them is that it is multi-tier, i.e., it has multiple application servers and multiple instances in the database. So when they want to run analytics, it gets extremely slow because a lot of tools are used to extract information. We came up with a solution, which customers across the manufacturing and IT/ITES segments are now discovering. That is why we see a very good adoption of converged systems across segments.

Q We hear a lot about software defined data centres (SDCs). Many players like VMware are investing a lot in this domain. How do you think SDCs are evolving in India?

The software-defined data centre really does have the potential to transform the entire IT paradigm and the infrastructure and application landscape. We have recently launched new products and services in the networking, high-performance computing, storage and converged infrastructure areas. They will allow enterprises to build software-defined data centres and hybrid cloud infrastructures. Big data, mobility, security and cloud computing are forcing organisations to rethink their approach to technology, causing them to invest heavily in IT infrastructure. So, when we are talking about software defined data centres, we are talking about a scenario in which it can be a heterogeneous